

largest road network after the US. Yes, you could ask if we have the money. Truth be told, funding isn't an issue at all. Commitment is.

The unfinished agenda is a long litany. In true Indian argumentative traditions, there has been no dearth of studies or committees though to advise successive regimes. The UPA had 55 committees within the first eight months of coming to power, including some headed by the prime minister. Expert view is that the issue was not money but implementation. Yet nothing has changed, which isn't surprising. The Administrative Reforms Commission headed by Congressman Veerappa Moily has delivered 12 reports but nobody knows if any has been implemented. The crux of the matter is that the system has insulated itself from accountability. Between 2004 and 2009, the Government pumped Rs 1,25,000 crore into education. Has it made an impact? We don't know. What we do know is that Myanmar has higher literacy than India. In five years, the UPA spent Rs 1,93,715 crore on rural development. It must have helped, but we will never know because the promise to convert outlays into measurable outcomes was given a quiet burial.

Sloth afflicts every department.

It is not just physical infrastructure or business processes that have suffered. Quality of education is a serious problem and so is lack of employment avenues. Yet, a pay review committee discovered that 25 per cent of posts of teachers in Central universities and colleges are lying vacant. Take counter-terror measures and basic law and order. India averages 142 policemen per lakh populace when the UN standard is 222. Clearly, in a billion-plus populace, any deficit—in this case eight lakh policemen—will show up as it has. But neither state governments nor the Centre has found it necessary to address the issue. This despite the fact that creation of these jobs and the need for them aligned political and national interests perfectly. Or take the issue of national identity cards which is a must for tackling terror. For over 10 years now different governments have stalled the idea for clearly political reasons. The time for politics and pilot projects is over. Why can't the Government select a smart card that can store data that includes medical and personal details? It can jump-start the process by at least issuing it to all those who have PAN cards, election identity cards or passports.

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Strangely, common sense solutions seem to elude governments. India needs to create over five million college and university seats to accommodate rising enrolment for higher education. Every year over four lakh students attempt the entrance tests for 2,400 IIT seats. We need to create capacity to meet the surge. At a different level, every year 4,50,000 students travel abroad for education spending between \$13 billion and \$18 billion at foreign universities. Many of these universities want to set shop here, creating campuses, jobs and research facilities, but have been denied permission. We need resources and processes to create capacity. With a six-crore population,

the UK has 125 universities and with 30.4 crore, the US has over 2,400. Both the countries have clearly benefited immensely as they have been able to attract talent while fuelling the economy. Joint ventures between these universities and Indian colleges is the obvious solution. As India acquires status on the geopolitical plate, it will need to create capacity and attract the best minds.

Time for a national agenda. The list of missed opportunities and obvious solutions is far too long. Blaming fractious coalitions and regional parties has its limits. After all the arrangement is consensual and national outfits are party to it. Secondly those in opposition cannot escape censure. After all you would expect a vigilant opposition to raise the alarm in any democracy, particularly on national issues. Budgets are allowed to be passed in a melee, absenteeism is

conspicuous during serious debates and Bills of public interest are left to lapse. Clearly not just the ruling coalitions but also the Opposition has failed the people.

For over two decades, mandates have been fractured but political formations have used common programmes to create a semblance of order enabling them to share the spoils of power. This has served the political class well but really the common minimum programme is a formula to stay in power. It is not an instrument that will deliver change. Perhaps a time has come for a common acceptable agenda to be drafted by both sides. This could include issues of national security, geopolitical stance, ensuring outcomes on social spending, problems of governance and measures to promote growth. This could form the basis for drafting out a national agenda and decoupling it from petty party politics. It would also insure India from itself and the volatility of a flat world. It may sound utopian but remember, failure is not an option.